

Operational UI Architecture: UMB-UI-004

The Diegetic Psychological Interface Constitution

Target Architecture: *Ashen Oath — Engine of Consequence*

Constitutional Principle

The interface exists to communicate Kaelen's lived experience—not expose engine variables.

Every screen must answer a single psychological question while preserving complete mechanical truth.

The player should never feel as though they are opening menus. They should feel as though they are opening another page of Kaelen's life.

Design Pillars

Every interface element must satisfy four constitutional pillars.

I. Mechanical Truth

The interface never lies about gameplay.

Hitboxes remain accurate.

Resources remain accurate.

Enemy positions remain accurate.

Cooldowns remain accurate.

The player may question Kaelen's interpretation of events—but never the underlying rules of combat.

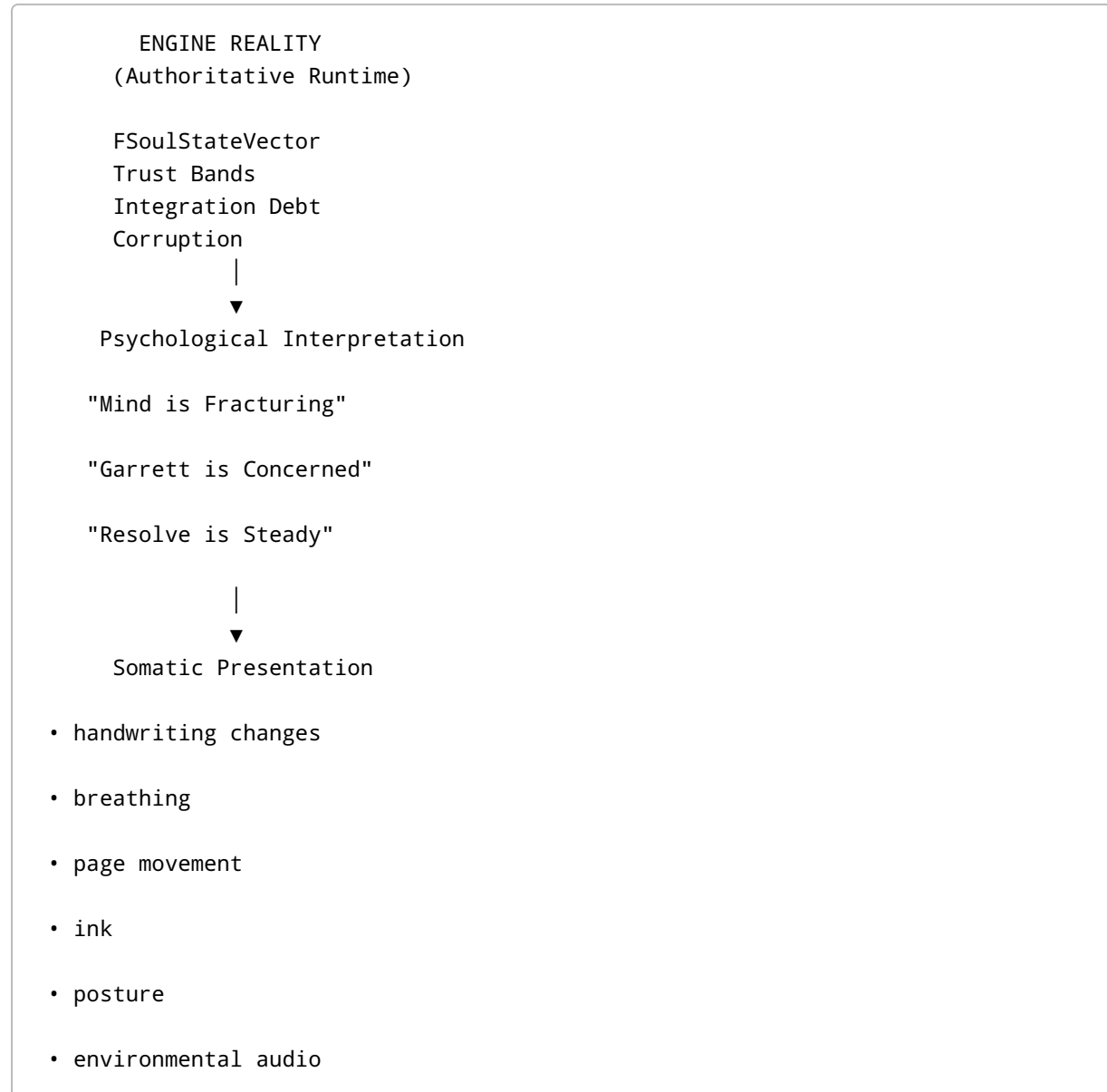
Psychology influences perception.

It never falsifies reality.

II. Psychological Translation

Engine variables are never presented directly.

Instead, every runtime value passes through three layers before reaching the player.



The player experiences the meaning of the variables rather than reading the variables themselves.

III. World Authenticity

Every interface belongs somewhere inside the world.

Nothing exists simply because "games need menus."

Interface	World Object
Inventory	Kaelen's field pack
Journal	Personal field notebook
Lore	Memory Palace
Progression	Heartstone Sanctuary
Relationships	Campfire conversations
Save Files	Journey Journals

Whenever possible, the interface should feel physically present.

IV. One Psychological Question Per Screen

Every screen has exactly one responsibility.

If a screen answers multiple unrelated questions, it should be divided.

Screen	Governing Question
Field Journal	What have we learned?
Equipment	What am I carrying?
Camp	How are we doing?
Memory Constellation	Why am I like this?
Heartstone Sanctuary	Who do I become next?
Journey Archive	Which journey is this?

This prevents interface bloat while keeping navigation intuitive.

The Three Layers of Truth

The player should never see raw engine data unless they explicitly request advanced information.

Layer I — Reality

Authoritative gameplay state.

IntegrationDebt = 0.81

Resolve = 0.67

Isolation = 0.42

GarrettTrust = 0.91

These values exist only for gameplay systems.

Layer II — Interpretation

The engine translates numbers into psychological language.

Mind State

Fracturing

Resolve

Determined

Isolation

Withdrawing

Garrett

Watching You Carefully

This is the player's primary information layer.

Layer III — Somatic Presentation

The interface expresses psychological state physically.

Examples include:

- handwriting becoming unstable
- pages turning more slowly

- breathing becoming shallow
- ink bleeding through paper
- bookmarks trembling
- subtle audio distortion

The interface itself becomes another storytelling system.

Interface Architecture

I. Field Journal

Question

"What have we learned?"

The journal is the root of the interface.

Rather than functioning as a codex, it becomes an evolving record of Kaelen's journey.

The journal permanently accumulates:

- expedition notes
- sketches
- companion marginalia
- field observations
- pressed flowers
- maps
- repaired pages
- burn marks
- blood stains
- integrated reflections

History is never erased.

Later reflections are written beside earlier mistakes.

II. Equipment

Question

"What am I carrying?"

Equipment is presented through physical inspection rather than inventory grids.

Weapons tell stories through wear.

Examples:

- chipped edge from Malakor
- repaired crossguard forged by Garrett
- soot from Blackwood Bridge
- leather darkened by sweat
- corruption veins spreading across Nightsteel

Statistics become secondary.

History becomes primary.

III. Camp

Question

"How are we doing?"

Camp replaces traditional party menus.

Instead of bars and percentages, companions communicate through behavior.

Garrett may:

- repair equipment
- sharpen traps
- avoid eye contact
- quietly observe Kaelen

Serafina may:

- press herbs
- read old scripture
- stare into the fire
- struggle to hide empathic exhaustion

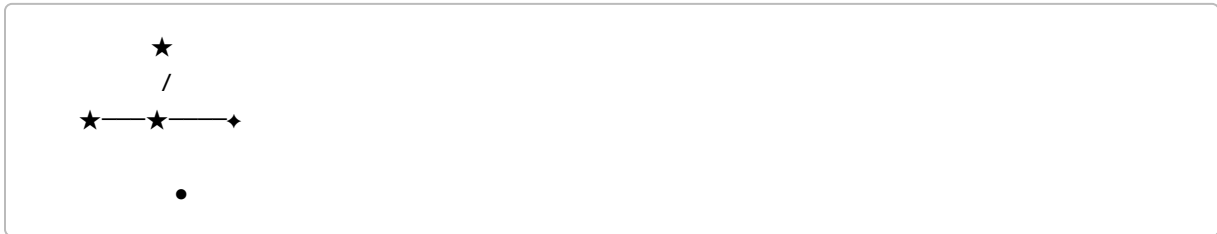
The player reads relationships through lived behavior.

IV. Memory Constellation

Question

"Why am I like this?"

The Memory Palace visualizes Kaelen's psychological landscape.



Visual language:

- Bright stars — defining memories
- Small stars — ordinary experiences
- Broken stars — fragmented trauma
- Dark pulsing stars — unresolved memories
- Golden stars — integrated experiences

Selecting a memory reveals:

- what happened
- how Kaelen interpreted it
- how companions interpreted it
- how it influences current identity

V. Heartstone Sanctuary

Question

"Who do I become next?"

The Heartstone is not a leveling menu.

It is a place of reflection.

The player reviews:

- unresolved memories
- companion perspectives
- interpretive lenses

- identity evolution

Progression emerges through understanding rather than accumulation.

Companion Presence Throughout the Interface

Garrett and Serafina should gradually inhabit the interface itself.

Examples include:

Garrett

- tactical annotations
- corrections in margins
- rough pencil sketches
- trap diagrams
- crossed-out reckless plans

Serafina

- pressed flowers
- illuminated script
- healing observations
- translated Eldorian phrases
- notes encouraging self-forgiveness

By the end of the game, Kaelen's journal should no longer feel like it belongs to one person.

It should feel like the shared history of three companions.

World Availability

The interface respects physical context.

Screen	Availability
Journal	Anywhere
Equipment	Anywhere
Camp	Active Campfires
Memory Palace	Camp or Heartstones
Heartstone Sanctuary	Heartstones only

Screen	Availability
Journey Archive	Main Menu or Sanctuary

World rules always take precedence over convenience.

Psychological Presentation Rules

The interface may communicate uncertainty.

It may never communicate falsehood.

Acceptable:

- handwriting distortion
- delayed page turns
- subtitle persistence
- ink bleeding
- breathing changes
- visual fatigue

Unacceptable:

- incorrect inventories
- false damage values
- fake hitboxes
- fabricated quest objectives
- misleading cooldowns

The player's trust in the simulation must remain absolute.

Closing Constitutional Statement

The interface is not a game menu.

It is the physical expression of Kaelen's memory, relationships, and identity.

Every page turned, every annotation discovered, every scar on a weapon, and every change in handwriting should remind the player that they are not managing statistics—they are witnessing the gradual reconstruction of a human soul.